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Every now and again the film industry throws up a hero who goes beyond the film industry. The last one was Amitabh Bachchan who wore his stardom lightly with his gracious manners and his rich baritone. He always behaved as if there was nothing to create a fuss about. Now the industry has orbited another such star: Shah Rukh Khan. It's a classic story. A Delhi brat with no god-father who through his talent, grit and market savvy, makes himself a Mr Bollywood and more. In contrast to Bachchan, he aggressively revels in his stardom and unabashedly milks it to the maximum.

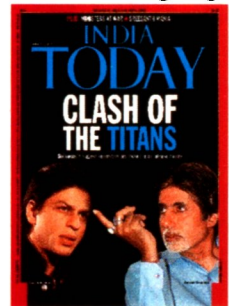
These days the man has become more than the sum of his movies. Well after the furore over his six-pack abs is over, everywhere you turn to, you seem to run into Khan. Every evening he is on television, fronting a new quiz show. Every other morning, he seems to be on the front pages cheering the Kolkata Knight Riders, the team he owns in the Indian Premier League. The same evening he will turn up at a product launch in another city, or an awards ceremony in another country. All this while shooting for a new comedy as well as an on-going quiz show. It's almost as if he has cloned himself.

His last two films made Rs 150 crore, one of which, *Om Shanti Om*, was also produced by him. Last year, he endorsed 21 brands, more than anyone else on TV. They say he writes most of his own scripts and has moved into production of ads and special effects.

I don't know him personally but as one of the most articulate and intelligent members of the Bollywood community, we invited Khan twice to speak at the INDIA TODAY Conclave but he ditched us after agreeing both the times. He too publicly declared when we carried a cover story on the Big B vs SRK clash (INDIA TODAY, January 2007) saying "What's that woman's name? I'll slap her when I see her next." That woman is our Executive Editor Kaveree Bamzai who wrote that cover story and has written this one.

For us his loutish behaviour is of no consequence. We are familiar with the arrogance of celebritydom. For us it's more important that we do the right story at the right time than standing on our ego. Bamzai has known Khan for many years and I am happy to report that he didn't slap her when she travelled to Kolkata with Photo Editor Bandeeep Singh for the Knight Riders IPL match to catch a glimpse of his hectic world. Says Bamzai: "He is like an Energizer Bunny who doesn't need batteries."

Khan is not only a phenomenon but a smart cookie. He knows stardom comes with an expiry date and is rapidly diversifying his business interests into a multi-media empire. He's today, at the age of 42, probably worth an estimated Rs 500 crore and growing. Not bad for a self-proclaimed 'Dilli ka goonda'.



Our Jan 2007 cover

Aroon Purie
(Aroon Purie)